

- 1 Silent, cause unknown.**
They stopped replying, and you do not know why.
Make it easy for a silent buyer to say no
SEND “Have you given up on solving this problem?” as the subject line, and nothing else.
NEVER Tell them you are closing their file.
Guess what happened. Let them correct you.
SEND Your best guess at their week in two ordinary sentences, such as “The proposal is sitting with finance.” Then give them a one-word way to answer.
NOT WHEN Your guess is about what they think of you. Guess about the process only.
Go back when something changes on their side
DO Wait for a change on their side, such as a new executive, a reorganisation or a competitor’s contract coming up for renewal. Write because of it, with something they can use even if they never buy.
NOT WHEN The only reason to write is your own calendar.
- 2 Not convinced it matters.**
They agree the problem exists, and it does not feel big enough to act on.
Build the business case with the buyer, including the cost of doing nothing
DO Work out with them, from their own figures, what carrying on as they are costs. Put staying put on the slide as its own option, before the demo.
NOT WHEN It is a renewal, or the buyer is already convinced and has gone quiet.
When they plan to build it with AI, run their own build-or-buy test with them
ASK Is there a product that already fits? Does it touch customer data or payments? Who maintains it after launch?
NOT WHEN You mean to argue that they cannot build it. Where the answer really is build, let that part go and sell the rest.
- 3 Convinced but afraid.**
They want it, and they are afraid of getting it wrong.
When the buyer keeps asking for more, ask what it is for
ASK What is this for, and what will it change in your decision? When the same request comes back, describe what you see in flat words, then stop talking.
NOT WHEN You have not earned their trust yet. The authors say this step only works on trust built earlier.
Take the risk off the table
DO Find out what your champion stands to lose. Then shrink the first step until they could survive it failing, such as a pilot with success criteria and a price agreed before it starts.
NOT WHEN The buyer still doubts the problem. This one is for a buyer who is convinced and scared.

- Offer one recommendation, not a menu**
SAY Which option you would pick, why, and what you would leave out for now.
NOT WHEN They are still comparing options. Keep the menu for the evaluation and the recommendation for the approval.
- 4 Cannot get it through the organisation.**
Your contact is convinced, and the rest of their company is not moving.
The mutual action plan
DO Write a short plan back from the day they want to be live, with a name and a date on every step on both sides, and the contract as one step in the middle.
NOT WHEN The dates come from your quarter end, or the plan runs past fifteen steps.
Ghostwrite what the champion has to send
DO Write the meeting request, the one-page business case and the note to the group yourself, and hand them over as rough drafts to edit.
NOT WHEN The drafts carry your branding or your pitch. Buyers discount help that reads as promotion.
Ask who decides if the committee cannot agree
ASK If you have not agreed by **date**, who decides?
NOT WHEN It is the last minute. Ask early enough to check the name against what that person actually does.
- 5 No reason to act now.**
Everyone agrees, and nobody needs it this quarter.
Ask what it would take
ASK “What would it take?” Write their conditions down and send them back as the plan.
NOT WHEN You are still arguing. If they start defending how things work today, stop and ask.
Park with a trigger
SAY “I hope this gets done and I’ll work towards it. It’s also possible it won’t. How much is it worth to you right now?” Then offer two paths: go ahead by a date, or park until a named event.
NEVER Say “let’s stay in touch” or “I’m closing your file”.
When they wait for their AI strategy, ask what it has to decide
ASK What will the AI strategy decide, who owns it, and when does it land? Which of those decisions changes this purchase?
NOT WHEN The strategy has no owner and no date. Then park the deal with a trigger instead of waiting.
- 6 Stuck in the machinery.**
They said yes, and now legal, security or procurement have it.
Get the contract through legal and security
ASK How many reviews are ahead of ours, and how many arrive each week? Before the contract goes out, date every redline step with your champion.
NEVER Present the stops as trouble. Name them as normal steps.

- Trade, don’t give**
SAY “We can look at 10% off if you commit to two years”, never “we can do 10% off”.
NEVER Give a discount for nothing, or invent an expiry.
- 7 The people or company changed.**
Your champion left, a new executive arrived, or the money froze.
When your champion leaves, hand the successor the case and the plan
SEND The business case and the mutual action plan, as the record of a project already running. Then test the successor as a champion from scratch.
NEVER Assume the successor inherits the conviction. They inherit the job title.
When a new executive arrives, open with an insight, not a re-pitch
SAY “It seems like **company** is focused on **X**.” Then ask what you got wrong.
NEVER Send a shorter version of the old pitch. They never approved it.
When a spending freeze stops your deal, ask what still gets approved
ASK What does the freeze exempt, and what has it let through since it began?
NEVER Put the deal back in the forecast just because an exception lane exists.
- 8 Existing-customer dynamics.**
It is a customer, and the renewal has gone quiet or they want to pay less.
When a renewal goes quiet, start with what they achieved
DO Book a call 90 to 120 days out on their results and next year’s goals, with everyone who has a say. Raise the renewal after that.
NEVER Open with the renewal.
When the customer wants to pay less
ASK What changed? Then trade scope, term or payment timing for price.
NEVER Offer the cheaper plan first. In a field experiment it made more customers leave.
- 9 We caused it.**
Something you did stopped the deal.
When your mistake stalled the deal, name it and lead with the fix
DO Name the mistake, then put the fix first and the regret last.
NOT WHEN You are accused of dishonesty you did not commit. Then deny it firmly instead of apologising.
Ask for their advice
ASK How would you word this for your finance team? One named problem, asked personally.
NOT WHEN It is about something they are weak at. Asking about that made the asker look worse.